

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Accountability Without Self-Punishment

Three weeks after Amara sent her letter to Iris, the email came back.

Amara had been checking her mother's email every day for those three weeks. Sometimes twice a day. Sometimes — when she was being honest with herself — five times a day. Her mother had told her, gently, that there might not be a reply. Iris's family might have moved again. Iris might not want to write back. Iris might be too busy with her new school. Iris might be carrying something Amara could not see.

The letter was for you both. But the writing was for you. You sent what you had to send. The rest is up to her.

Amara had said okay. Amara had checked the email anyway.

On a Thursday afternoon in mid-November, when Amara came home from school, her mother was waiting at the door. Her mother had that look on her face. The *I have news* look.

"Amara. Iris wrote back."

Amara did not say anything. She just held out her hand.

Her mother had printed the email. She handed it over.

Amara took the printed page. She walked, slowly, to the couch. She sat down. She put the page on her lap. She read it.

Dear Amara,

I have been thinking about you too. I forgive you. Thank you for writing. I love you.

— Iris

P.S. I have to tell you something. After we moved to Cincinnati, I felt really bad about myself for a long time. I thought I had done something to make those girls mean to me. I thought maybe I was just not a nice enough person. My new school is okay. I have a friend named Madeleine. She is okay. But I have been thinking about our old school a lot. When your letter came, I cried. My mom asked me if I was sad. I said I was happy and sad at the same time. I think you have been carrying this for a long time. So have I. I am glad you wrote. I love you.

— Iris, again

Amara read it.

Then she read it again.

Then she read it a third time.

By the third time, she was crying. Not loud crying. Quiet crying. The kind of crying where the tears just go down your face and you do not really feel them coming.

Her mother sat down on the couch next to her. She put a hand on Amara's back. She did not say anything.

After a long time, Amara said, "She thought it was her fault."

"Sweetheart, she did."

"It wasn't her fault."

"No. It wasn't."

"It wasn't my fault either, was it. I mean — I should have stood up for her. But I didn't make the girls be mean. I was seven."

Her mother thought about this.

"Amara. You did one thing that was not your best — you stayed quiet. That is a real thing to apologize for. You apologized. Iris forgave you. That part is done. You are not

responsible for what the other girls did. You did not make them mean. You did not even know how to make them stop. You were seven. The grown-ups in that school should have noticed and stopped it. They did not. That is on them. Some of the responsibility belongs to other people. Not all of it is yours."

Amara nodded slowly.

"I have been carrying it all," she said.

"I know, sweetheart. You have. You can put down the part that was not yours. The part you should have done differently — you can hold that piece, learn from it, and put it down too. Iris already forgave you for it."

Amara put the email on the coffee table. She wiped her face.

"Mom?"

"Yes."

"Can I write Iris back?"

"Of course you can."

"Now?"

"Now."

Amara went to her room. She took out a fresh piece of paper. She wrote:

Dear Iris,

Thank you for writing me back. I cried too when I read your letter. I want to tell you something. The girls who were mean to you — that was their fault, not yours. They were mean. You did not make them mean. You were not the problem. You were a good friend. I know this because I was your friend, and I knew you better than they did.

I am sorry it has taken us both two years to figure this out. I am glad we are figuring it out now.

Can we be friends again? Even from far away? I can write to you. We could be — pen pal friends. Or pen pal best friends. Or

just whatever you want.

I love you too.

Love, Amara

She read it. She gave it to her mom. Her mom typed it up and sent it.

Two days later, Iris wrote back: *YES. Pen pal best friends. Forever.*

Amara, when she read this, did something she had not done in months. She laughed — a big real laugh — and her mother heard her from down the hall and came in and asked what was funny, and Amara held up the email and her mother read it and laughed too.

They both laughed for a while.

This is what accountability without self-punishment looks like.

Accountability is: *I see what I did. I am taking responsibility for the part that was mine. I am making it right.*

Self-punishment is: *I am the worst person. I will carry this forever. I do not deserve to feel better.*

The two look similar from the outside. They are very different on the inside.

Amara had been doing self-punishment for two years. The letter to Iris turned it into accountability. *I see what I did. I am sorry. I am making it right.* The accountability had a beginning and an end. The self-punishment had no end.

When the accountability ended — when the work was done — Amara was allowed to put it down.

She put it down.

This took the rest of November. By Thanksgiving, the weight had lifted enough that Amara could feel the difference. She slept better. She laughed more easily. She wrote a list of things she was good at on the back of an old worksheet, and

the list had nine things on it, not three, and she did not erase any of them.

This is what self-forgiveness, the real kind, makes possible. It is not about pretending you did not do the thing. It is about doing the work, putting the weight down, and walking forward without dragging the weight behind you.

Amara, that November, started walking forward.

She had a friend named Iris in Cincinnati who would write to her, by hand, with stickers on the envelopes, for the next nine years. That is not in this book. But you should know it is what happens.